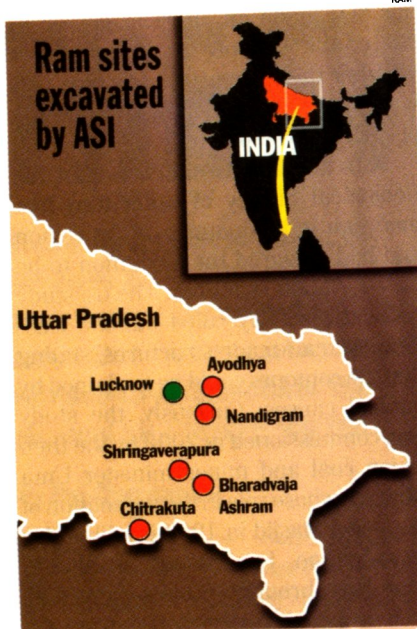
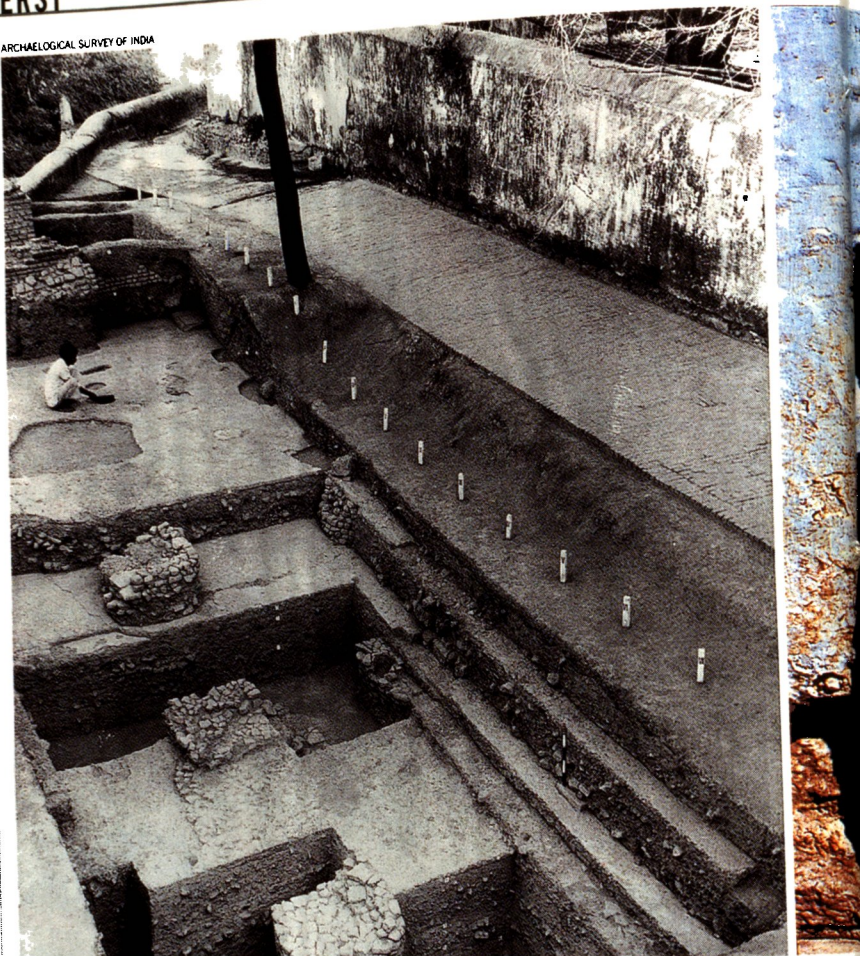




THE RAM QUEST

- In the 1970s, ASI excavated six of the sites named in the epic.
- It found proof of human occupation in these places dating back to 1,000 B.C. but direct evidence about Ram was lacking.

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gious connection to Adam's Bridge was rarely ever brought up in such interactions. Most of the objections were over ecological reasons, as the area involved lies in the vicinity of the Gulf of Mannar marine reserve, which is known for its biological diversity. There were also questions about the loss of livelihood to fishermen, security issues over LTTE using it as a navigable zone for its Sea Tigers, and over the overall economic viability of the entire project. More recently, after the 2004 tsunami, experts opined that Adam's Bridge had prevented the southern tip of India from being inundated.

After Bharati's call for a CSI report, the BJP government did not push for any further scientific research on the bridge's archaeological significance. It was only after the project was inaugurated in July 2005 that Sangh Parivar organisations such as the Vishwa Hindu Parishad raised the issue of religiosity in the courts, as did Janata Party President Subramanian Swamy, who filed a writ petition in May this year, wanting to know why Adam's Bridge shouldn't be declared a national

monument. Some experts are aghast that such questions are being asked at all. "It is unfortunate that the issue is being given a religious and communal touch. It will be wise not to mix mythology and science," says Christopher Jayakaran, a consulting geologist. Project officials point out that while Adam's Bridge is 30 km long, they would be dredging only a 300-m stretch. Most of the bridge would remain untouched.

It is not as if ASI investigations would have come up with "incontrovertible proof" of the bridge's history. As Nayanjot Lahiri, professor of history at DU and an authority on ancient Indian civilisations, says, "The past may be an arena to score political points, but archaeology as a discipline has rarely succeeded in furnishing proof to the faithful about haloed events and personages valorised in traditional ac-

counts." What ASI didn't point out in its affidavit is that it had in fact taken up a national project called the Archaeology of the Ramayana Sites way back in 1975. It was headed by Lal, who excavated six sites connected with Ram's epic story. These were Ayodhya, Ram's birthplace, Shringaverapura, where Ram, Lakshman and Sita crossed the Ganga during their exile, Bharadvaja, where they stayed with the sage, Chitrakuta, the jungles in which they lived, Nandigram, where Bharata ruled in Ram's absence, and Parihar, where Sita was abandoned by Lakshman (see graphic).

Perhaps the most detailed excavations were done in Ayodhya, first by Lal in the late 1970s and more recently after the fall of the Babri Masjid by a team led by ASI's B.R. Mani. The findings provided evidence of the site being inhabited by humans as far back as

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